



VENTURE CAPITAL FIRM Athera Venture Partners' office is tucked away in a small lane in Bengaluru's Domlur area. It is housed in a modest building, and the set-up is spartan, a sharp contrast to the VC landscape, where firms are generally known to be more ostentatious.

In many ways, the set-up is emblematic of Athera's functional approach of focussing its attention on picking the right companies to invest in, something it prides itself on, and paying as little heed to other things as possible.

In the large, austere conference room, which just has some wood panelling, the firm's four General Partners gather for a freewheeling chat. Soft-spoken Samir Kumar, 62, his tone firm, speaks of how he and his colleagues—General Partners Parag Dhol (56), Rutvik Doshi (48), and Rajiv Mehta (46)—look at a business plan. "Of course, over time, that process has been fine-tuned, but at the core, we look at a 10x return." That is ambitious on any given day, but it's something that Athera, which translates to journey in Sanskrit, has gotten better at.

Athera, originally known as Inventus India, was launched in 2008 and has so far invested in over 40 companies, deploying about ₹1,200 crore across its four funds, and has an active portfolio of 19 companies. Till its third fund in 2018, investments were made from a global pool. It participates largely in Series A and opportunistically in seed funding, with cheques in the ₹5–35 crore range.

Some of its bets have netted it stellar returns upon exit, done through a combination of IPOs, M&As, and cash. There's ticket booking platform redBus, which delivered 12.4x returns after it was ac-

quired by Ibibo Group, before MakeMyTrip picked it up in 2013. PB Fintech, parent of insurance platform Policybazaar, yielded an impressive 21.3x when it went public. Other exits include Instahealth after selling it to Practo, while FundsIndia was acquired by Westbridge.

Buoyed by these successes and learning from some failures, Athera is cruising ahead with its single-minded focus on finding sustainable technological solutions to address some pressing challenges confronting society.

GOING ABOUT IT QUIETLY

The list of companies Athera has invested in is diverse; it has embraced a host of sectors—from consumer internet and enterprise/SaaS (software-as-a-service) to deep/emerging tech. "We are sector-agnostic, but there is method to the madness. There are clear boundaries, and we will invest only in businesses that we understand," says Rutvik Doshi, who cut his teeth in software before joining Athera

GROWING TALL

- From its first fund in 2008, which had ₹146 crore, each new fund has been bigger than the previous one
- In terms of returns, the second fund has performed the best so far

FUND NAME	FUND	YEAR	FUND SIZE (₹ CRORE)	MOIC
Inventus Capital Partners (Mauritius) Ltd	Fund 1	2008	146.0	2.3
Inventus Capital Partners II Ltd	Fund 2	2013	323.5	4.2
Inventus III India Fund	Fund 3	2018	360.8	1.1
Athera Fund IV*	Fund 4	2023	900.0	1.0

NOTE MOIC: MULTIPLE ON INVESTED CAPITAL;

*FIRST CLOSE WAS ON SEPTEMBER 30, 2023; FINAL CLOSE IS SCHEDULED ON MARCH 31, 2025

SOURCE ATHERA VENTURE PARTNERS